

⑥ What were the principal provisions of the Cabinet Mission plan of 1946? Analyze how its limitations and responses of major political parties contributed to the eventual partition of India. [15m]

The Attlee's govt. in March 1946 sent the Cabinet Mission plan via Pethick Lawrence, Stafford Cripps & A.V. Alexander to advance India towards self-governance via peaceful transfer of power.

Provisions

- ① Formation of an interim govt. at the centre.
- ② Rejected the creation of Pakistan citing administrative, economic, military issues. The principle of communal self-determination also laid the creation of
 - Hindu majority western Bengal.
 - Sikh Hindu majority Ambala, Jalandhar & parts of Punjab.

③ Grouping of Provinces

- Section A: Bombay, Madras, CP, UP, Bihar, Orissa } Hindu Majority
- Section B: NWFP, Punjab & Sindh. } Muslim majority
- Section C: Bengal & Assam.

④ Constitution making machinery - Electing the constituent assembly by the method of proportional representation from provincial assemblies.

well-structured explanation of the grouping of provinces into three sections.

Good introduction establishing the context of the Cabinet Mission. You could briefly mention the growing demand for independence and communal tensions.

Factual error: The Cabinet Mission Plan didn't create Hindu-majority western Bengal or Sikh+Hindu majority areas in Punjab. It rejected Pakistan but didn't propose these specific communal divisions.

UPSC

Answer Questions in NOT MORE THAN the Word Limit specified for each in the Parenthesis.
(Specimen Answer Booklet - For Practice Purpose Only)

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389 members = 292 Provincial Assemblies + 93 from Princely States + 4 chief Commissioners provinces.

In the Constituent assembly, the members of groups will sit separately to form the Constitution of provinces & if possible then group constitution too.

The entire constituent assembly will agree on a union constitution, whereby group constitution will take precedence over provincial & union constitution.

⑤ Federal proposals - a) 3 tier division of legislative & executive powers at provincial, group & union level.
b) Union of India to only control Defence, Communications & Foreign affairs.

c) The paramountcy of British over princely states shall lapse.

d) Provinces free to leave the group after 1st general election & can question the reconsideration of union & group constitution after 10 years.

Responses of INC & Muslim League

① The muslim league considered the grouping to be compulsory in order to use it as a stepping stone for creation of Pakistan.

② INC considered grouping to be optional because



Incorrect constitutional hierarchy: Group constitutions wouldn't take precedence over the union constitution. The union would be supreme in its designated areas.

Good explanation of federal proposals showing understanding of the decentralized structure.

NWFP & Assam where it had won majorities in recent elections were put in muslim majority groups (B & C).

③ Muslim League wanted ^{now} provisions to be able to amend the union constitution immediately, not after 10 years.

④ INC wanted provinces to have option to not join a group in the first place, instead of leaving after 1st general elections.

Limitations

① Ambiguity in "Grouping" - Both the parties interpreted to grouping differently, catered to their objectives.

② Lack of a dispute resolution mechanism which led to Nehru's declaration of 10th July 1946, followed by League's withdrawal from long term plan it agreed to. This led to Jinnah calling for Direct action which marked 16th August 1946 as the last nail in the coffin of united India.

③ Federal proposals aimed at creating a decentralized state which was not the goal of INC.

Thus, the failure of Cabinet Mission resulted in an unstable govt. interim govt. that led to Attlee's declaration on 20th Feb 1947 which sowed the seeds of final partition via 3rd June Plan.

Your identification of limitations is accurate, particularly the ambiguity in grouping.

Strong conclusion connecting Cabinet Mission's failure to events leading to partition.